

78 CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS REACHES AMERICA

captain Bartolomeu Dias rounded the southern tip of Africa. Soon another Portuguese navigator, Vasco da Gama, led the push to round the Cape and pressed on across the Indian Ocean, linking Europe and Asia for the first time by ocean route.

Since Portugal dominated the sea route along the African coast, Portugal's European neighbor and rival Spain needed to find an alternative route, if it was to gain access to the riches of the East. Although educated people knew by this time that the Earth was round, they did not know about the existence of the Americas. An alternative way to the East seemed, therefore, to be to sail west across the Atlantic. This route seemed especially attractive to the many seamen—including Christopher Columbus—who believed the planet's diameter to be rather smaller than it actually is.

Seeking sponsorship

In 1485, Columbus presented to John II, king of Portugal, a plan to sail across the Atlantic to the Spice Islands. John refused to invest in the scheme, however. This

was partly because Portugal was already exploring the West African coast with some success, and partly because the experts John consulted about the proposal were skeptical about the distances involved.

Columbus cast his net more widely, seeking backing from the powerful maritime cities of Genoa and Venice, and sending his brother to England to do the same—but still he received no encouragement. He therefore turned to Ferdinand of Aragon and Isabella of Castile, the “Catholic Monarchs” who jointly ruled Spain. At first they turned him down, their navigational consultants also skeptical about the length of his proposed route, but eventually, after protracted negotiations, they agreed to sponsor the voyage. Securing a new trade route would certainly bring material rewards, but Isabella also saw the voyage in terms of a religious mission that could bring the light of Christianity to the East.

Columbus sails west

Having been granted viceroyship and governorship of any lands he could claim for Spain, plus other benefits including

Columbus's voyage was a bold undertaking. Despite a general understanding that the world was spherical, many believed the westward journey was doomed to fail, fearing the crew would die of thirst before ever reaching land.

